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The Truth Takes Time.

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EDUCATION

The Endemic Ecosystems of DU Sub Fests: CADET'23

A dispatch from Kirori Mal College's CADET'23 — Delhi University's annual NCC fest — where twenty-three institutions gathered and found, as usual, nothing much to say to one another. On the recursive culture of apathy that defines DU's sub-fest circuit.

BY MOULI SHARMA

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New Delhi: The 9th of February kicked off the annual NCC fest of Delhi University's old, prestigious, big-name alumnus-heavy Kirori Mal College. Boys and girls in combat uniforms with 5kg Aashirvad Aatta equivalent rifle dummies carried out the section attack on the front lawns ("arrowhead formation" "classic") as a crowd consisting of 30-person teams along with their moral supporters of over 23 institutions (including those from outside of the directorate) surrounded the grounds looking anywhere but at them.

Culture finds a way.

It is a reasonable claim to make - albeit still a claim - that it is ultimately not alienation or ignorance but familiarity that breeds apathy. An observation that at the end of the day seemed more worthwhile a subject to write down this piece of pseudo-news about than any number of lacklustre open ground concerts where the noise is too loud, the food stalls too desperate and the number on the cheque cashed by the artist too long was simply this: the world is recursive. Arvind Kejriwal used a phrase in his speech at the Directorate General of NCC on the 8th of January at this year's CM Visit for the Republic Day celebrations: "[] a microcosm of the country." But a national integration camp is not what is a microcosm and our nation is not what it is a microcosm of.

The world is recursive. Society recreates itself within itself, and whether it be an unmoving resilience of the human spirit or a biological vulnerability to the goddamn sound of bleating, a man will create tradition where he cannot find it, if only so he has something to get used to.

The various niches of DU Fests - departmental, ECA, NCC, NSS, what have you - are a case study in self-sustaining ecosystems. A "normal" person walking into the gates of CADET'23 (excellent name, by the way, truly an epitome of the spirit of originality and creativity the military and modern education are so insistent upon inculcating) will find certain sights to gaze upon. Goats in a petting zoo. Infiltrators in a cult. Look how they greet each other, arms a stiff set by their sides, white lie caressing their lips ("*Jai Hind everyone*"). Look what they care about, creases on their pants and 3 buttons over their waists. Look how they think; they don't.

Somewhere past the point of no return of zoning out on the rifles aimed directly between my eyes as the section attack droned on, my friend had thrust a green piece of sponge and a white bottle of shoeshine into my hands. Multipurpose polish, that's what she'd called it.

"What, seriously?"

"Seriously."

"Fuck off."

She'd just given me a look, then took the polish back and started brute-forcing the last of it out onto the sponge. I rolled my eyes and moved to a ledge nearby, waving her to come over. The front crease of the uniform is as delicate as it is permanent. You can't be bending over in half 30 minutes from your inspection, and a shoe has to shine. Unfortunately for her, by the time she'd managed to get a millimetre of her multipurpose polish out onto her flimsy dish sponge and walk over to me another of her subordinates had beat her to it (you shine one guy's shoes, you shine the whole squad's). One who had several complaints to make about my shoe-shining skills.

"Maybe just polish it yourself then. She's doing it, isn't she?"

"Yeah I'm doing it, just shut the fuck up."

"That's enough! I'll do it," said my friend. Owner of and first in line for the polish, and incidentally, the Junior Under Officer of our company. The senior most in our batch.

"No, you can't," the whiner said. Took her shoe off the ledge.

"Put it back up."

"Please don't."

"What did I say?"

For the life of that dying bottle, dear old JUO managed to polish every single one of those 9 pairs of drill march shoes, some better than others. She stood there frowning beside me after the formality of brushing a dry sponge over her own shoes and wordlessly handed her precious materials back over to me.

"This is pretty wet," I'd said then. Silence.

"Probably still has a substantial amount of polish in it." I lent over and pressed the last dredges of multipurpose shoeshine onto her dust-covered boots. Best I could.

"It works on normal shoes, too."

"That's nice."

"I said, it works on *normal shoes, too*."

I looked up at her and her eyes moved down to my shoes and back to me. She raised an eyebrow. I rolled my eyes and pressed the sponge down on my own no longer black sport shoes. She smiled.

"See?"

"I do."

"It's useful, isn't it."

"They don't need polish, dude they need a turbo wash."

"Yeah, but if you polished them you wouldn't have to turbo wash them."

I gave her a look. She smiled.

There is a certain isomorphism to self-contained social subsystems that will go over the head of anyone lost to the great big symbolism of the shoe. A good leader in an NCC fest leading a squad drill team is the same as one in a hackathon is the same as one in band is the same as the one on the council, even if their languages don't translate. Did you go to school with the same people you met at college? Are you working with the same people you sit with at dinner? Do you want to?

You move past the arrogance of believing yourself to be more than the common Indian idiot, and you'll realize that the eccentricities you find voyeurising the unbent knees and the abdominal cry of a military squad are just variants of your own. You are guilty of worship, you've just given your god a different name. You are the cult and you are the petting zoo. Your normalcy is an illusion.

The best you can hope for in life is people you'd douse your sports shoes in wax for. A multipurpose polish that works on all kinds of shoes. A dummy rifle that slaps back. A tug of war rope that isn't long enough. Good fest or bad fest because everything everyone everywhere is the same. The best you can hope for is to find something you cannot predict.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



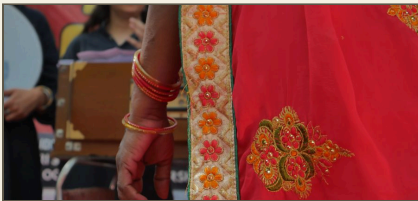
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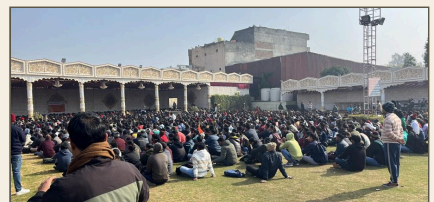
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